

Part I: Overview Information

Department of Veterans Affairs

Funding Opportunity Announcement/Request for Applications (FOA/RFA)

Number: BX-24-038, CX-24-038, HX-24-038, RX-24-038

Title: Psychedelics Parent Merit Review Award (I01)

Catalog of Federal Domestic Assistance Number(s): 64.054

Participating Organizations: Veterans Health Administration, Office of Research and Development (VA-ORD)

Components of Participating Organizations: Biomedical Laboratory Research and Development Service (BLR&D), Clinical Science Research and Development Service (CSR&D), Health Services Research and Development Service (HSR&D), Rehabilitation Research and Development Service (RR&D)

Announcement Type: New

Applications submitted in response to this FOA/RFA must be submitted through [Grants.gov](https://www.grants.gov) using the *VA-ORD Application Guide SF 424 Research & Related (R&R) (VA-ORD SF 424)* and other forms available on the VA-ORD intranet: <http://vaww.research.va.gov/funding/electronic-submission.cfm>.

NOTE: The instructions in this FOA/RFA may differ from the general instructions in the *VA-ORD SF 424*. **The instructions in this FOA/RFA supersede all other guides.**

Companion FOA/RFA: BX-24-201, CX-24-201, HX-24-201, RX-24-201 Psychedelic Pre-application (I02): <http://vaww.research.va.gov/funding/rfa.cfm>.

Key Dates:

Release/Posted Date: January 5, 2024

Pre-application Receipt Date(s): see [Table 2](#) in Part II, Section III.

Opening (earliest submission) Date(s): Standard dates apply; see [Table 2](#) in Part II, Section III.

Application Deadline(s): Standard dates apply; see [Table 2](#) in Part II, Section III.

Peer Review Date(s): Standard dates apply; see [Table 2](#) in Part II, Section III.

Earliest Anticipated Start Date(s): Standard dates apply; see [Table 2](#) in Part II, Section III.

Additional Information: Not applicable

Expiration Date: December 31, 2024

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Part II: Full Text of Announcement

Section I. Funding Opportunity Description

Executive Summary

Purpose: VA is committed to safely exploring all avenues that promote the health of our Nation's Veterans. This cross-service FOA/RFA is intended to outline the requirements for applications studying Psychedelic compounds for mental health conditions in **Biomedical Laboratory Research and Development (BLR&D)**, **Clinical Science Research and Development Service (CSR&D)**, **Health Services Research and Development (HSR&D)**, and **Rehabilitation Research and Development (RR&D)** within the Office of Research Development. In late September 2023, VHA held a state-of-the-art conference on psychedelic treatments focused on two major objectives to: 1) better understand the current state of scientific evidence and create a strategic framework for future psychedelic treatment research; and 2) determine the necessary steps for potential, system-wide, clinical implementation of these treatments. One of the major outcomes of this process was a plan to develop this FOA/RFA for Psychedelic research projects, particularly testing MDMA (3,4-Methylenedioxymethamphetamine) and Psilocybin for the treatment of mental health conditions (including PTSD and Depression).

The Merit Review Award Program is an intramural funding mechanism to support investigator-initiated research conducted by eligible VA-ORD investigators at VA medical centers (VAMCs) or VA-approved sites. In response to this FOA/RFA, investigators can submit a proposal to any of the four (4) services (BLR&D, CSR&D, HSR&D, or RR&D). Due to the nature of the evidence for Psychedelics at this time and the funding available, ORD is not considering projects/trials funded through the Cooperative Studies Program and/or studies with more than 10 sites.

This FOA/RFA accepts applications that involve:

- Human subjects clinical and rehabilitation research
- Animal/pre-clinical research
- Investigations of novel service delivery methods (e.g., group-based, post-PAT integration optimization, simultaneous administration, new psychotherapy protocols, telemedicine, Smartphone Apps, EMA monitoring devices, involvement of caregivers, families, and peers)
- Investigations of impact of concomitant medications (e.g., SSRIs)
- Dose-finding studies (dose optimization, timing and number of dosings)
- Studies of potential predictive biomarkers for response/nonresponse
- Clinical and rehabilitation outcomes studies using Psychedelic compounds in conjunction with an Evidence Based Therapy
- Rehabilitation studies on the impact of using Psychedelic compounds to improve physical and psychological functional outcomes as well as quality of life
- Health Services focused effectiveness studies and hybrid (effectiveness and implementation) studies that optimize strategies to get effective treatments to Veterans faster

- Develop, validate and apply systems science or engineering models for enhancing the effectiveness, quality, safety and efficiency of Psychedelics use by Veterans especially across different settings (e.g., primary, mental health specialty, inpatient/ED settings)

Areas of Special Emphasis/Consideration:

- Inclusion of diverse and underserved patient populations
- Attention to sex/gender differences
- Biospecimen collection (storage at VA Science and Health Initiative to Combat Infectious and Life-Threatening Diseases [VA SHIELD])
- Common data elements (see information below)
- Measures of/controlling for expectancy bias
- Veteran input on study design and procedures
- Assessments of the adequacy blinding for patients and providers
- Transdiagnostic approaches and outcomes
- Legal, financial, social stigma, personal, religious and other barriers in access and use of Psychedelic compounds

Common Data Elements:

To assist in building the evidence-base to support wide-spread application of these compounds, VHA is requesting (where possible) that human-subjects research projects funded by this mechanism collect, report and store the following common data in a VA central repository (e.g. REDCap and VA SHIELD).

- Hamilton Depression Rating Scale
- CAPS-5
- WHODAS 2.0
- Biospecimens (whole blood and EDTA plasma) pre-post

Research Objectives

The focus of research to be supported by this FOA/RFA is preclinical, translational, clinical, rehabilitation or health services/implementation research in the Veteran population using either MDMA or Psilocybin compounds for the treatment of mental health conditions.

Thus, this FOA/RFA does not consider the following to be priority programmatic areas – applications that:

- Focus primarily on other Psychedelic compounds outside of MDMA and Psilocybin.
- Focus on pain or headache.
- Focus on substance use disorder.
- Focus on cancer anxiety/distress.
- Focus on Parkinsons or other neurodegenerative diseases.
- Recruit or use data/samples from non-Veteran populations or non-VA providers.

Section II. Award Information

Psychedelics Parent Merit Review Award, (I01)
 BX-24-038, CX-24-038,
 HX-24-038, RX-24-038

Mechanism of Support: This FOA/RFA will use the Merit Review Award I01 activity code for investigator-initiated VA research and Just-in-Time (JIT) information concepts to ensure all VA regulations and policies are met.

Funds Available and Anticipated Number of Awards: Availability of funds is dependent on Congressional appropriation.

Number of Applications and Funded Awards: An investigator may be named on no more than two (2) applications to this FOA/RFA in any given review cycle. Investigators are eligible to submit one application as a Principal Investigator and one application as a Co-Investigator or Multiple Investigator (MPI); however, an application that is submitted to this FOA/RFA **may not** be submitted concurrently to any other FOAs/RFAs within VA-ORD.

NOTE: A Pre-application (I02) must be submitted and approved prior to submission of a full research application.

Resubmissions: If a Merit Review Award application is reviewed, but not selected for funding, ORD allows the submission of up to two (2) revised (Resubmission) applications. In general, it is expected that PD/PIs would submit three (3) applications within four (4) cycles. **NOTE:** A Pre-application must be submitted for each review cycle. See FOA/RFA BX-24-201, CX-24-201, HX-24-201, RX-24-201 Pre-application (I02) for instructions: <http://vaww.research.va.gov/funding/rfa.cfm>.

Renewals: Funded Merit Review Awards can be renewed by submitting a competitive application for an additional project period of up to four (4) years. A renewal application may be submitted up to one (1) year prior to the end date of the ongoing Merit Review Award. **NOTE:** A Pre-application must be submitted for each review cycle. See FOA/RFA BX-24-201, CX-24-201, HX-24-201, RX-24-201 Pre-application (I02) for instructions: <http://vaww.research.va.gov/funding/rfa.cfm>.

Number of PD/PIs: Multiple PD/PIs are accepted for this FOA/RFA.

Application Materials: See [Section III](#) for application materials.

General Information: For general information on VA-ORD SF 424 and submission to VA-ORD, see <http://vaww.research.va.gov/funding/electronic-submission.cfm>.

Eligibility Information

Eligible Institutions/Organizations: All VAMCs with an active research program are eligible.

Eligible Individuals: The Merit Review Award Program is an intramural program to fund research conducted by VA-salaried investigators at VAMCs or VA-approved sites. A PD/PI shall hold an M.D., Ph.D., or equivalent doctoral degree.

Eligible Project Directors/Principal Investigators (PD/PIs): Investigators assigned the PD/PI role must have at least a 5/8ths VA appointment at the time the Merit Review Award is funded (see [Program Guide 1200.15: Eligibility for VA Research Support](#)). Contract clinicians cannot be VA employees (have a direct, VA-paid appointment) and therefore may not seek research funding from ORD, even if the terms of the contract permit or include research activities.

NOTE FOR BLR&D SUBMISSIONS: The eligibility criteria for this funding mechanism differs from those for most BLR&D funding opportunities. Additionally, receiving funding through this FOA/RFA will not automatically confer eligibility to submit an application to any other Merit Review Award or Pilot Project Award FOA/RFAs issued by the BLR&D Service.

The VA employment status, including a 5/8ths appointment of each PD/PI must be indicated in the Letter of Support (LOS) of the Medical Center Director. If a clinician or non-clinician PD/PI does not have a current, 5/8ths VA-paid appointment, the LOS from the Medical Center Director must include a commitment to offer the PD/PI a 5/8ths (or greater) appointment at the VAMC if the application is approved for funding and that the person is currently eligible for a Federal position.

In addition, PD/PIs must be current with all requirements related to intellectual property (VA invention documents and certifications); submission of annual progress reports (Research Performance Progress Reports/RPPRs); final RPPRs; clinical trials registration; and results reporting (i.e., ART/clinicaltrials.gov) for existing and previous awards.

Non-VA investigators who have an M.D./Ph.D. equivalent are eligible to serve in the role of Co-investigator, but they cannot be listed as such on the budget. The Co-investigator role may be described in the proposal narrative. On the budget they should be reflected as a consultant or as having an Intergovernmental Personnel Act (IPA) assignment, if appropriate. If they are providing research services to VA through a contract, the cost of the contract should be included on the budget under all other expenses. Collaborators from outside of the U.S. may only serve as unpaid consultants.

A Site PI must meet the same qualifications as a Study PI; this includes a minimum of a 5/8th VA appointment or waiver of the 5/8th appointment eligibility requirement, a M.D./Ph.D. or equivalent.

See [Program Guide 1200.15: Eligibility for VA Research Support](#) for additional guidance.

Multiple PD/PIs: The decision of whether to submit an application with a single PD/PI or multiple PD/PIs is the responsibility of the “Contact” PD/PI (identified in Box 14 of the *VA-ORD SF424 Cover*) and the applicant VAMC and should be determined by the goals of the project. The Contact PD/PI Psychodelics Parent Merit Review Award, (I01)

must be affiliated with the VAMC in eRA, be the primary lead on the proposed work and be the contact for all communications about the proposed work. Only individuals assigned the PD/PI role in the *Budget* and the *Senior/Key Personnel Profile* are considered PD/PIs. The justification for including more than one (1) PD/PI must be included in a *Multiple PD/PI Leadership Plan* and may be considered by reviewers as part of their evaluation of the application. All MPIs must meet the same eligibility criteria as the contact PI. Each PI must bring unique and distinct expertise for the completion of the project. Identification of multiple PD/PIs may not be used to exceed budget caps.

Funds Available

Duration and Budget: PD/PIs may request funding for a maximum of four (4) years for non-clinical trials and single site clinical trial applications and five (5) years for multi-site clinical trials, based on the total project maximum amount outlined below. There is no annual budget cap; thus, variable funding may be utilized as long as the overall budget cap (based on years requested) is maintained. The salary for all personnel, including the contact PD/PI identified in Box 14 of the *SF 424 Cover*, is included in this cap.

Budget Item	Limit for Single Site Studies/Clinical Trials	Limit for Multi-VAMC Site Clinical Trials
Budget Cap	- For two (2) years, \$600,000 - For three (3) years, \$900,000 - For four (4) years, \$1,200,000	For a two (2)-site trial, a total: - For two (2) years, \$600,000 - For three (3) years, \$1,125,000 - For four (4) or five (5) years, \$1,500,000 - Additional \$100,000 per site per year for each additional site above 2 sites (up to 10 sites).
Duration	Up to four (4) years	Up to five (5) years

Exceptions to the Duration and/or Budget Caps: Rare exceptions to the award duration and/or budget caps may be granted prior to full research application submission for compelling circumstances. A duration and/or budget exception waiver request must be submitted as a part of the Pre-application (I02) submission to Grants.gov/eRA. See the companion FOA/RFA BX-24-201, CX-24-201, HX-24-201, RX-24-201 for Pre-application (I02) instructions for waiver requests (<http://vaww.research.va.gov/funding/rfa.cfm>).

Applications submitted with more than five (5) project years or a budget exceeding the total award budget cap (based on years requested) will not be accepted for review without a waiver approval memo. If a waiver is granted, a copy of the waiver approval memo must be included in the [Letters of Support](#). A waiver does not guarantee that a project will be funded at the level requested.

Section III. Application and Submission Information

Request Application Information

See the *VA-ORD SF 424* for step-by-step guidance.

Other – Special Criteria

Use of Common Data Elements: All human-subjects research studies funded under this mechanism are required to collect and submit to a central repository the information listed in Part II of this document. In addition, any study for which common data elements (CDE) are available, this FOA/RFA expects that investigators will use the applicable core measures (see [NIH CDE Collections](#)). If the proposed research is not compatible with the CDEs, investigators must supply a detailed justification as to why these CDEs will not be incorporated into the research.

Biospecimens:

It is expected that applications under this FOA/RFA will collect data and biospecimens, to include genomic data derived from use of biospecimens, in a manner that permits sharing and use for secondary research purposes. Applications should include commitment to deposit data/specimens into a centralized VA repository upon study completion.

VA Phenomics Library Initiative: The Centralized Interactive Phenomics Resource (CIPHER) (previously the VA Phenomics Library [VAPheLib]) is a catalog and knowledge sharing platform of VA electronic health record (EHR)-based phenotype algorithms, definitions and metadata that aims to optimize Veterans' health data, drive collaborative research and improve clinical operations. CIPHER initially began as a collaborative effort within VA to build on the Million Veteran Program (MVP) and Cooperative Studies Program (CSP) Phenotype Annotation Library. CIPHER includes an online user interface to easily access a curated knowledgebase of standardized VA phenotype metadata. The web-based platform is also a tool for storing and sharing phenotyping methods, resources, and best practices, with the goal of enhancing collaboration and communication across VA research, operations, and clinical communities. CIPHER is currently supported by the MVP on behalf of ORD, CSP and VA Informatics and Computing Infrastructure (VINCI). This effort is part of an enterprise-wide approach to provide a resource for phenotypes that can be used in ORD supported research and for investigators to share their work.

Applicants proposing to develop and validate new phenotypes as part of their VA-funded research should plan to contribute their phenotyping algorithm, codes, and validation processes to CIPHER. Researchers also should check to see if a phenotype they need is already in the library. The VA Phenomics Library contains a total of 3,683 phenotypes at different stages of development. Browse CIPHER and learn more about CIPHER through an archived CyberSeminar.

Million Veteran Program (MVP):

MVP is a national genetics research initiative of the VA-ORD. The purpose of MVP is to create a longitudinal cohort of at least one million Veterans to understand better how genes, lifestyle behaviors, and military exposures impact health and illness, and to bring personalized medicine to VA health care. Veterans who volunteer to join MVP provide access to their medical records, complete a baseline survey, an optional lifestyle survey, and provide a blood specimen. Currently, MVP has over 970,000 Veterans participating.

MVP data access is open to all VA researchers through Merit Awards. Since 2015, VA has funded over 70 VA research projects using MVP data. These projects represent VA investigators from all four VA-ORD research services and the Cooperative Studies Program. The project teams have helped MVP test the computational infrastructure, and the regulatory and administrative frameworks around data access in addition to increasing the scientific knowledge regarding the genetics of various chronic illnesses and traits impacting U.S. Veterans.

Applicants interested in the opportunity to access MVP data should register for an account in GenHub (<https://genhub.va.gov>) where they can explore aggregate data with the cohort builder and results explorer tools from the MVP cohort.

MVP Data Use Request (New Requirement)

A new feasibility check step for proposals with MVP aims must be completed prior to submission of a Pre-application and full research application to the FOA/RFA. Investigators wishing to access MVP data and include MVP aims in their proposals must now submit a MVP Data Use Request to MVP via email to MVPLOI@va.gov **AND** receive an MVP Approval Memo in advance of the appropriate Pre-application/LOI submission deadline. This is a new feasibility check step for proposals with MVP aims must be completed prior to submission of a Pre-application/LOI and is a requirement **separate and in addition to Pre-application/LOI requirements**. **Information on the MVP Data Use Request process can be found here:** <https://genhub.va.gov/file/view/772565>. Investigators need to register for a GenHub account from their VA computer before accessing the information.

Location of Research Space: It is expected that the PD/PI and VA co-investigators will perform all of the VA-funded research within a VA facility or VA-leased space in accordance with [Program Guide 1200.16: Offsite Research](#). If any of the proposed work will be carried out in non-VA space, a waiver to perform the research off-site must be obtained. The waiver request must indicate if there is a memorandum of agreement, memorandum of understanding or any such arrangement with the owner of the off-site space.

If all the proposed work will be conducted in non-VA space, **a full off-site waiver is required prior to the full research application submission**. The full off-site waiver request must be included in the Pre-application (I02) submission to Grants.gov/eRA. See the companion BX-23-201, CX-23-201, HX-23-201, RX-23-201 Pre-application (<http://vaww.research.va.gov/funding/rfa.cfm>).

If only a portion of the proposed work will be conducted in non-VA space, **a partial off-site waiver will be required as part of the JIT process** for applications selected with an intent-to-award.

Content of Application Submission

Prepare applications using this FOA/RFA and VA-ORD SF 424 guidance and applicable templates found on the VA-ORD intranet: <http://vawww.research.va.gov/funding/electronic-submission.cfm>. Unless otherwise noted in this FOA/RFA, all instructions contained in the VA-ORD SF 424 must be followed. **Failure to follow instructions may cause delays in submission or withdrawal of applications from review.**

R&R Other Project Information: [Table 1](#) explains the content required for each file attached to Item 12 “Other Attachments” of the *R&R Other Project Information*.

File Naming and Formatting Guidelines: File names for **Attachments 1-10** are mandatory and may not be changed; incorrect file names will be flagged as errors. See [Table 1](#) for all file naming conventions.

When attaching **Appendix** files (attachments 11 and higher), only the descriptor may be edited. The descriptor is the name of the appendix document. If descriptive text is included in an attachment name before the “.PDF” as described in the examples in bold, eRA will auto-generate a warning message concerning the attachment name. This warning can be ignored. Descriptors must be less than 50 characters and use only standard characters (A through Z, 0 through 9, spaces). Descriptors may not include special characters (&, *, %, /, etc.) or underscores. If a descriptor is more than one (1) word, use a space to separate them (no underscore, dash, etc.). File names are **not** case sensitive. *NOTE:* Altering any other parts of appendix file names may cause parts of an application to be excluded from the final electronic image or for the attachments to appear in the wrong order.

All applications must be self-contained; thus, URLs, hyperlinks, and video clips may **not** be used to provide information necessary to the review. URLs may only be placed in the *Biographical Sketch* and *Bibliography and References Cited* attachments. VA-ORD strongly encourages PD/PIs to carefully review the application for URLs prior to submission. **Any submission with URLs and hyperlinks placed anywhere else except the *Biographical Sketch* and/or *Bibliography and References Cited* attachments will be withdrawn from review.**

URLs **are** allowed within official documents that cannot be altered, such as letterhead (Letters of Support) or published articles/manuscripts (Appendix attachments); however, URLs should **not** be included in the body/content of a Letter of Support. *NOTE:* Reviewers are under no obligation to view supplemental material; moreover, they are cautioned that they should not directly access a website, as it could compromise their anonymity.

Table 1: Other Project Information Attachments for Item 12

Attachment <i>File Name</i>	Instruction (See the VA-ORD SF 424, <i>Attachments for Item 12</i> for further guidance.)
Introduction to Revised Application <i>01_VA_Intro.pdf</i>	Page Limit: 3 For Resubmissions only. Substantial scientific changes must be marked in the text of the application by bracketing, indenting or changing typography. A vertical bar drawn in the margin may be used as long as changes in text are also indicated by bracketing, indenting or changing typography. Do not underline or shade the changes. Deleted sections should be removed and described, rather than retained and marked as deletions. If the changes are so extensive that essentially all of the text would be marked, explain this in the introduction.
Specific Aims <i>02_VA_Specific_Aims.pdf</i>	Page Limit: 1
Research Plan <i>02a_VA_Research_Plan.pdf</i>	Page Limit: 14 The organization of the plan is at the discretion of the PD/PI. Although there is no specified page limit for each section, be as succinct as possible. In general, the Research Plan should include the following sections: Background and Significance • Briefly sketch the background leading to the present application, critically evaluate existing knowledge (published literature, clinical trials, etc.) and specifically identify the gaps that the project is intended to fill. • State concisely the importance and health relevance of the research described in this application by relating the specific aims to the broad, long-term objectives. • Explain how achieving the aims of the application will advance scientific knowledge or clinical practice. • Describe the effect of these studies on the concepts, methods, technologies, treatments, services or preventative interventions that drive this field. • Explain the use of drugs, including pharmacological and toxicological data as appropriate. Preliminary Studies Provide an account of the PD/PI's preliminary studies pertinent to this application, including their preliminary experience with and outreach to the proposed racial/ethnic group members, when relevant. This information will help establish the investigator's background and experience that qualifies them to pursue the proposed project. Scientific Review Groups (SRGs) generally view preliminary data as an essential part of a research application. Preliminary data often aids the reviewers in assessing the likelihood of the success of the proposed project.

Attachment <i>File Name</i>	Instruction (See the VA-ORD SF 424, <i>Attachments for Item 12</i> for further guidance.)
	Research Design and Methods <i>NOTE:</i> Due to unforeseen impacts caused by the coronavirus pandemic, on Aug. 6, 2020, VA revised the deployment schedule for implementation of its new EHR system. The revised timeline preserves the department's 10-year plan to roll out the EHR nationwide by 2028. The new VA-wide EHR system and associated Cerner systems will Go Live in the Pacific Northwest (VISN 20) in 2021, with future deployment continuing by VISN across the country over the next 10 years. In designing studies, please beware that the transition has potential implications for data availability. Please email the ORD EHRM workgroup (ResearchEHRM@va.gov) with questions about the potential impact of the Cerner implementation on the research plans. Resource links, current updates and FAQs can be found on the EHRM and "Research" page of the Research Resource Guide (RRG). For administrative purposes, proposals should discuss possible ways to mitigate the effects of any data disruption. • Describe the research design conceptual or clinical framework, procedures and analyses required to be used to accomplish the specific aims of the project. Include how the data will be collected, analyzed and interpreted. • Describe any new methodology and its advantage over existing methodologies. • Describe any novel concepts, approaches, tools or technologies required. • Discuss the potential difficulties and limitations of the proposed procedures and alternative approaches to achieve the aims. • Provide a tentative sequence or timetable for the project. • Point out any procedures, situations or materials that may be hazardous to personnel and the precautions to be exercised. • Descriptions of various comparison groups. • Participant recruitment strategies, if applicable, including control groups. • The criteria to be used for participant selection, the criteria for assignments to various study groups and the number of participants expected to be recruited each year until the conclusion of the study should be clearly detailed. • Data describing participant population inclusion/exclusion criteria at recruiting sites, including number of participants available, should be provided as evidence of feasibility. <i>NOTE:</i> A targeted/planned recruitment summary table and targeted/planned enrollment table must be included as appendices. • Description of the statistical analysis plan including the

Attachment File Name	Instruction (See the VA-ORD SF 424, Attachments for Item 12 for further guidance.)
	statistical approach to the questions being investigated, calculations of sample size and other comparative measurements. - Explanation of how various data measures will be categorized and assessed. Implementation & Dissemination Plan for Health Services Research An <i>Implementation & Dissemination plan</i> is required for health services projects intended to develop an intervention in a clinical setting or model of care. - Describe how the research findings will be translated into changes in policy or practice, and to determine proactively the steps required to accomplish that. - For projects that are more methodological or exploratory in nature, discuss how objectives are aligned with the goals of specific VA stakeholders and what next steps are contemplated to apply research findings to achieve changes in care or policy. - Include a conceptual plan that indicates how and when research findings will be disseminated and, if appropriate, implemented, among provider and Veteran groups. - Explain how the study is aligned with leadership/stakeholder goals and discuss the key stakeholders who will eventually implement/disseminate the final project. - Identify any conditions or barriers that may preclude implementation of the research findings or products. - Identify plans and promising mechanisms (beyond professional publications) that may be used to facilitate dissemination and implementation.
VA Career Plan	Do not use. Does not apply.
Mentoring Plan	Do not use. Does not apply.
Progress Report 03_VA_Prog_Report_Pubs.pdf	Page Limit: 5 Progress Reports are required for: - All applications from a PD/PI who has had any VA funding, including ongoing or completed Merit or CDA funding. - Renewal applications. <i>NOTE:</i> Progress reports are not required for HSR&D or RR&D applications.
Human Subjects 04_VA_Human_Subjects.pdf	No Page Limit <i>NOTE:</i> A targeted/planned recruitment summary table must be included as a separate appendix. This recruitment table guides

Attachment <i>File Name</i>	Instruction (See the VA-ORD SF 424, <i>Attachments for Item 12</i> for further guidance.)
	a proactive approach toward recruitment to ensure on time completion of the study. In the event the study falls behind the benchmarks provided in the recruitment table, be prepared to submit a contingency plan via a <i>Project Modification Request</i> for review. The required targeted/planned recruitment summary table template can be found at: http://vawww.research.va.gov/funding/electronic-submission.cfm under Additional Format Pages, Service-Specific. BLR&D: vhacoblcsrdrev@va.gov CSR&D: vhacoblcsrdrev@va.gov HSR&D: vhacoscirev@va.gov RR&D: rrdreviews@va.gov Use of non-Veteran subjects or non-VA Providers is not allowed.
Vertebrate Animals <i>05_VA_Animals.pdf</i>	No Page Limit Additionally, research that uses any canine, feline, or non-human primate must be directly related to an illness or injury that is combat-related. Provide an explanation of how the proposed study meets the requirement that the scientific objectives “are directly related to an illness or injury that is combat-related”. Work proposed with these species must also include a detailed description of how it fits into the regulatory pathway seeking approval for investigational use. If the study involves a drug or biological agent in non-Human Primates, the application must additionally include toxicology study findings from smaller animal models (e.g., rats, mice) sufficient to address FDA IND requirements.
Multiple PD/PI Leadership Plan <i>06_VA_Multiple_PI.pdf</i>	No Page Limit When considering multiple PD/PIs, the structure and governance of the PD/PI leadership team, as well as the knowledge, skills and experience of the individual PD/PIs, will be factored into the assessment of the overall scientific merit of the application. The justification for including more than one (1) PD/PI must be included in a Multiple PD/PI Leadership Plan and may be considered by reviewers as part of their evaluation of the application. Each PI must bring unique and distinct expertise for the completion of the project. The Contact PD/PI will be the primary lead on the proposed work and be the contact for all communications about the proposed work.

Attachment <i>File Name</i>	Instruction (See the VA-ORD SF 424, <i>Attachments for Item 12</i> for further guidance.)
Consortium/Contractual Agreements <i>07_VA_Agreements.pdf</i>	No Page Limit
Director's Letter <i>08_VA_Director_Letter.pdf</i>	No Page Limit The VA employment status, including a 5/8ths appointment of each PD/PI must be indicated in the Director's Letter. If a clinician or non-clinician PD/PI does not have a current, 5/8ths VA-paid appointment, the Director's Letter must include a commitment to offer the PD/PI a 5/8ths (or greater) appointment at the VAMC if the application is approved for funding and that the person is currently eligible for a Federal position.
R&D Committee Letter	Do not use. Does not apply.
Letters of Support <i>08b_VA_Letters_of_Support.pdf</i>	No Page Limit REQUIRED FOR ALL SUBMISSIONS – Involved Personnel: • A list of all named personnel and collaborators in the application with their institution (VA and non-VA) and city, state must be included in the letters of support section. <i>ALL personnel and collaborators who are named in the application, including but not limited to: PD/PI(s), co-investigators, personnel with ANY role in the study, IPAs, consultants, mentors, collaborators, advisory panel members, letter writers, active partners (Program offices) must be included. If someone is only named in the bibliography or Biographical Sketch section, they do not need to be included.</i> • A table of contents for the letters of support that lists each letter writer's • Name • Position • Office/institution Do not send separate original hard copies or email PDF copies of LOS to the Director. These letters must be included as a scanned part of the <i>Letters of Support</i> attachment (Item 12, "Other Attachments," 8b. <i>Letters of Support</i>) to be considered a part of the proposal. Letters should be submitted on the official letterhead of the individual's supporting institution. For individuals with appointments to VA and an academic affiliate, the LOS must come from VA.

Attachment <i>File Name</i>	Instruction (See the VA-ORD SF 424, <i>Attachments for Item 12</i> for further guidance.)
	- All memoranda, Budget Waivers and other LOS should be addressed to the Service Director and must include the corresponding PD/PI name(s), project title, VA facility, signature and date. BLR&D: Dr. Holly Krull CSR&D: Dr. Miriam Smyth HSR&D: Dr. Amy Kilbourne RR&D: Dr. Patricia Dorn - A LOS is required from the VA facility director acknowledging the role of and support for each proposed PD/PI. - A LOS is required from each co-I, consultant and advisory board member confirming their willingness to participate on the study team. A single LOS is sufficient for all individuals at the same institution. For Resubmissions: A LOS may only be resubmitted within the same year it was originally dated/submitted. - This section must also include all approval letters for waivers (Budget Cap, Duration of Study, Off-site Research, Eligibility, Inclusion of Videos.). Do not include the Pre-application approval notice in this attachment. Do not include URLs in the body/content of a Letter of Support.
Data Management and Access Plan <i>09_VA_DMAP.pdf</i>	No Page Limit The required DMAP template (Version: 7/29/2016) can be found at http://vaww.research.va.gov/funding/electronic-submission.cfm.
Financial Disclosure <i>10_VA_Financial_Disclosure.pdf</i>	No Page Limit For a sample document: http://vaww.research.va.gov/funding/electronic-submission.cfm.
Appendices (11, 12, etc.) <i>11_VA_Appendix_1_Descriptor.pdf</i> <i>12_VA_Appendix_2_Descriptor.pdf</i> NOTE: If more than ten (10) appendices are uploaded for an application (i.e., starting with Appendix 21), the system will not recognize the above naming convention. For these appendices, use	Appendices must be uploaded in the preferred order for the application. To check for the correct ordering of attachments, review the Bookmarks and Table of Contents in eRA Commons during the two (2)-day application viewing window. The first appendix should be an alphabetized list of abbreviations used in the application. Use the descriptor "Abbreviations" in the file name (11_VA_Appendix_1_Abbreviations.pdf)

Attachment <i>File Name</i>	Instruction (See the VA-ORD SF 424, <i>Attachments for Item 12</i> for further guidance.)
the filename Appendix+underscore+11+underscore_descriptor. As with Appendices 11, 12, etc., upload each file in the order in which they should appear in the final application: Example: Appendix_11_Descriptor.pdf	If Human Subjects will be included in the project, Appendix 2 should be a targeted/planned recruitment summary table. (For template files, see http://vaww.research.va.gov/funding/electronic-submission.cfm, Additional Format Pages, Service Specific). 2nd Appendix Descriptor: Enrollment Recruitment Table Appendices 3, 4, 5 and 6 should be a narrative on recruitment and retention of study participants (if applicable), a multi-site management plan (if applicable), study milestones and timelines and Veteran Engagement Plan (if applicable), respectively. 3rd Appendix Descriptor: Recruitment and Retention Plan 4th Appendix Descriptor: Multi-Site Management Plan 5th Appendix Descriptor: Study Milestones and Timeline 6th Appendix Descriptor: Veteran Engagement Plan Recruitment and Retention Plan (if recruiting human subjects): • Recruitment and Referral sources, including detailed descriptions of the census/rate of new cases and anticipated yield of eligible participants from each source; • Procedures that will be used to monitor enrollment and track/retain participants for follow-up assessments; • Strategies that will be used to ensure a diverse, representative sample; • Potential recruitment/enrollment challenges and strategies that can be implemented in the event of enrollment shortfalls (e.g., additional outreach procedures, alternate/back-up referral sources); • Evidence to support the feasibility of enrollment, including descriptions of prior experiences and yield from research efforts employing similar referral sources and/or strategies. Multi-Site Management Plan (if applicable): • How sites and investigators will be selected; • How procedures, data analysis, and data storage will be integrated across different sites and elements within a project. Plans should address data management, reliability and quality control; • How the overall managerial and administrative responsibilities will be divided in a team (i.e., which laboratory will coordinate various parts of the project and which will be responsible for overall coordination), as well as leadership and joint decision-making; • What procedures will be used to assure sharing of

Attachment <i>File Name</i>	Instruction (See the VA-ORD SF 424, <i>Attachments for Item 12</i> for further guidance.)
	resources across sites in the team, as well as reliability and quality control of data and resources as appropriate and consistent with achieving the goals of the program; • How close collaboration, coordination, and effective communication will be maintained among sites in a team through regular meetings (in person/teleconference). This plan should include frequency and types of contact between participating researchers, and documenting and disseminating group meeting proceedings; • The plans for project data coordination, including standards and integration, quality control, issues with missing data and plans for ensuring comprehensive transparency of data reporting/sharing across sites, as appropriate and consistent with achieving the goals of the program; • The plans for ensuring experimental rigor and control of bias (e.g., with sample size estimation, data handling), as appropriate; • The plans for completion of the research project should a key member leave the group, including plans to replace the PD/PI, if needed; • The plans for publication and authorship rights and a process for arbitrating disagreements on publication and other issues among linked applications. • Performance requirements for sites and plans for remediation when a site does not meet targets for enrollment or other performance requirements. Milestones and Timelines: • Objective, quantifiable and scientifically justified milestones; • A proposed timeline for reaching important study milestones such as: (a) finalizing the study procedures and training participating clinical site staff; (b) finalizing the intervention manual and assessment protocols, including fidelity measures/procedures, where applicable; (c) enrolling 25%, 50%, 75% and 100% of the sample; (d) completing all subject follow-up assessments and data collection activities, including data quality checks; (e) analyzing and interpreting results; and (f) preparing de-identified data and relevant documentation to facilitate data sharing, as appropriate. Veteran Engagement Plan (if recruiting human subjects): Proposals should include a Veteran Engagement Plan. The appropriate level of engagement will vary with the nature of the project and the target of any interventions included. Researchers could consult with local Veteran Engagement Groups, include Veterans on the study team, use a Consortium of REsearch (CORE) Veteran Engagement panel, and/or develop a project-specific Veteran Engagement approach. See Additional Review Criteria Considerations – Veteran Engagement Plan for details.

Attachment File Name	Instruction (See the VA-ORD SF 424, Attachments for Item 12 for further guidance.)
	For approved supplemental materials: After the application has been assigned to a SRG in eRA Commons, contact the Scientific Review Officer (SRO) at least three (3) weeks prior to the application deadline for approval to discuss logistics for submission. Supplemental materials must be received by the SRO prior to the application deadline. Only include videos that demonstrate devices and experimental data with a temporal element (shows how something functions or occurs over time or demonstrates movement or change). No devices or other media will be accepted. If the video is included in an attachment, the application will be withdrawn from review. If the video has been approved by the SRO, it should be emailed to the SRO prior to the application deadline. The video should not exceed 2 minutes; .mp4, .mov, .avi and .wmv formats are accepted. The file may not exceed 25 MB. Sufficient descriptive information must be provided within the research plan to understand the information presented in the video, as not all reviewers may be able to access the video, depending on technological constraints.

Summary Budget Worksheet and R&R Budget

See the VA-ORD SF 424, Section 3.7 Summary Budget Worksheet (SBW) and R&R Budget for guidance on budget content for Sections A-L. The SBW worksheet template is available at <http://vawww.research.va.gov/funding/electronic-submission.cfm>. Verify that the total in the SBW and R&R Budget match and that the budget request does not exceed the allowable amount (per year and project total) found in the FOA/RFA unless an approved waiver has been obtained.

Personnel (Sections A & B): Salary commensurate with the actual effort expended on the project by the PD/PI (or other study personnel) may be requested. Salaries are included in the budget cap. Furthermore, salary support may be requested *only* for activities that are uncompensated from other sources.

Travel (Section D): Leave Section D blank. Travel costs must be included in Section F, Line 8. Travel costs, including conference registration fees, for presenting research findings at scientific meetings may not exceed \$2,000/year (in total, not per individual). Individuals traveling must be VA employees. Expenses in year one will require strong justification to explain how results will be available for dissemination so soon in the project. Travel costs required to perform the proposed specific aims are permitted if included in the travel table and clearly justified in the *Budget Justification* (Section L).

Publication Costs (Section F): Publication costs in year one will require strong justification to explain how results will be available for dissemination so soon in the project.

Intergovernmental Personnel Act (IPAs) (Section F): IPAs with 5/8ths (7.5 calendar months) effort or greater for the award will require clear and convincing justification for why these individuals are not VA paid employees. **Do not** include costs for IPAs in Section A or B; these costs must be included in Section F. Other Direct Costs.

Submission, Review and Anticipated Start Dates

Deadlines: Avoid delays and misunderstandings by reading and following the instructions carefully. [Table 2](#) contains deadlines for Merit Review Award Program applications. Depending on the investigator's particular circumstance, requests for off-site or eligibility waivers or approval to exceed budget limits may be needed. The VAMC R&D Office's Associate Chief of Staff (ACOS) and Administrative Officer (AO) can help determine which approvals may be required.

Table 2. Deadline*, Review and Award Dates

Submission Cycles	Cycle I (Summer- HSR&D and RR&D)	Cycle II (Fall- BLR&D and CSR&D)	Cycle III (Winter- HSR&D and RR&D)	Cycle IV (Spring- BLR&D and CSR&D)
MVP Data Use Request	March 29	June 28	September 29	December 29
Pre-application (I02) – Letter of Intent & Waiver Request Submission Deadline <i>Applications submitted without a letter of intent for the current review cycle and necessary waiver approvals will be withdrawn.</i>	April 1	April 1	October 1	October 1
Begin Submitting Applications to RFA	May 15	August 15	November 15	February 15
Down-to-the-Wire Application Submission Deadline <i>After this date the full two (2)-business day application viewing window cannot be used.</i>	5 business days prior to the Verification Deadline			
Application Submission Deadline to Grants.gov <i>Changed/corrected applications submitted after this date will be withdrawn.</i>	3 business days prior to the Verification Deadline 5:00 p.m. local time			
Verification‡ Deadline in eRA <i>Once verified, an application is considered final and no other version will be accepted for review.</i>	June 15	September 15	December 15	March 15

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Review and Award Cycles	Cycle I (Summer- HSR&D and RR&D)	Cycle II (Fall- BLR&D and CSR&D)	Cycle III (Winter- HSR&D and RR&D)	Cycle IV (Spring- BLR&D and CSR&D)
Scientific Merit Review	August	November- December	February-March	May-June
Administrative Review	August- September	January- February	March-April	July-August
Earliest Project Start Date	Upon completion of JIT	Upon completion of JIT	Upon completion of JIT	Upon completion of JIT

*If the deadline falls on a weekend or Federal holiday, the due date is the next business day.

*Verification occurs on the 3rd business day after receipt of an application with no errors or only warnings.

Pre-application (I02): Submitting a Pre-application (I02) to Grants.gov/eRA (LOI and waiver requests [budget, duration, eligibility, full off-site]) is the first step in the application process. **A LOI (Preapplication) is required for each review cycle, including resubmissions and renewals.** See [Table 2](#) above. For guidance on submitting a Pre-application (I02), see the companion FOA/RFA BX-24-201, CX-24-201, HX-24-201, RX-24-201 Pre-application (<http://vaww.research.va.gov/funding/rfa.cfm>).

Application Submission and Processing: For guidance, see the *VA-ORD SF 424*.

VA-ORD will not penalize PD/PIs for an eRA Commons or Grants.gov system issue; however, unless there is documentation of a processing error at either Grants.gov or eRA Commons, **applications that fail to meet either the application submission or verification deadline will not be accepted for review.** In such cases, prior approval will be required for late submission. The respective Service Program Review staff must be notified of any Grants.gov or eRA system errors prior to the submission deadline.

BLR&D: vhacoblcsrdrev@va.gov

CSR&D: vhacoblcsrdrev@va.gov

HSR&D: vhacoscirev@va.gov

RR&D: Kristy-Benton-Grover, Kristy.Benton-Grover@va.gov

Upon receipt, applications will be evaluated for completeness by Program Review staff. **Applications that are incomplete or fail to meet formatting requirements outlined in the VA-ORD SF 424 will not be accepted for review.**

Administrative non-compliance issues that will cause an application to be withdrawn from review, include but are not limited to:

- Applications submitted without an approved Pre-application (LOI) for the current review cycle.

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- Applications must be self-contained; thus, URLs and video clips may **not** be used to provide information necessary to the review. URLs may only be placed in the *Biographical Sketch* and *Bibliography and References Cited* attachments. VA-ORD strongly encourages PD/PIs to carefully review the application for URLs prior to submission.
- Applications must contain a Summary Budget Worksheet and Budget Justification attachment. If either document is missing, the application cannot be adequately evaluated.
- Applications must meet both the Application Submission Deadline to Grants.gov and Application Verification Deadline in eRA noted in Table 2.
- Appendices or other sections must not be used to circumvent the stated page limits.
- Biographical Sketch template [OMB No. 0925-0001 and 0925 0002 \(Rev. 10/2021 Approved Through 09/30/2024\)](#) or later version is required.
- For Resubmission or Renewal applications, the correct previous full research e-application number (example RX001234) must be entered for the Federal Identifier field (*SF 424 Cover, 4.a.*); entering the wrong Federal Identifier will prevent the system from processing the application or will mis-identify it as belonging to another investigator or project.

Once an application has verified, no additions or changes will be accepted, unless requested by the Service Program Review staff. The only exceptions are official letters of acceptance for publication of manuscripts submitted by the PD/PI. These may be sent by email to the respective Service Program Review staff at any time prior to the meeting date.

BLR&D: vhacoblcsrdrev@va.gov

CSR&D: vhacoblcsrdrev@va.gov

HSR&D: vhacoscirev@va.gov

RR&D: Kristy Benton-Grover, Kristy.Benton-Grover@va.gov

Section IV. Application Review Information

Review and Selection Process

Overview: Applications submitted in response to this FOA/RFA will be reviewed through a two-tier system. The first level of review will be performed by an SRG composed of scientists who have expertise in relevant scientific disciplines and current research areas. The purpose of the SRG is to evaluate the scientific and technical merit of applications. The SRG does not make funding decisions. The second level of review will be performed by program staff, based not only on considerations of scientific merit (as judged by the SRGs), but also on the relevance of the proposed study to the mission, programs and priorities of VA-ORD. Final funding decisions are made at the discretion of the respective Service Director and approved by the Investigators, Scientific Review, and Management Council.

Discussed and Non-Discussed Applications: The scientific peer review of research applications may include a process in which only those applications deemed by the reviewers to have the highest scientific merit, potentially the better half of the applications under review, will be discussed and assigned an impact score at the SRG meeting. This process allows the reviewers to focus their discussion on the most meritorious applications.

Before the SRG meeting, each reviewer assigned to an application will provide a preliminary score for that application based on the review criteria described below. The preliminary scores will be used to determine which applications will be discussed. *NOTE:* While not all applications need to be discussed, **all applications are reviewed and receive written critiques**; an application that is not discussed may be very appropriate for Resubmission, depending on the comments in the written critiques.

If an application is not discussed, the PD/PI will not be given a priority score and will be advised that the proposal was not discussed by the full panel, and any Resubmission needs to address the key issues raised in the written critiques.

Scoring: SRG members are instructed to evaluate research applications by addressing the review criteria described below. Each application that is discussed will receive a final global impact score from each eligible Subcommittee member (without conflicts of interest) following the SRG discussion. Each member's global score will reflect their evaluation of the overall impact of the project in its entirety, rather than an arithmetic formula applied to the reviewer's evaluation of each criterion. This FOA/RFA uses a scoring scale of 1.0 to 5.0 (with 1.0 being the best possible score); the final impact score for each discussed application will be determined by calculating the arithmetic average of all the eligible members' scores and multiplying the average by 100.

Following the review meeting, PD/PIs will receive a written Summary Statement, which contains the Program Description/Abstract and Project Narrative (Relevance) sections from the submitted application, all of the reviewers' written comments and a roster of the review meeting participants.

For applications discussed by the SRG, the Summary Statement will also include a summary of the members' discussion during the review meeting, the final impact score, recommendations of the SRG and administrative notes of special considerations.

Research Project Evaluation Criteria

Reviewers will evaluate the following:

Significance:

- Is the scientific significance, theoretical foundation and originality of the proposed research reflected in the PD/PI's understanding and appreciation of other research done by others in the same field (e.g., thorough and current literature review) and its relationship to the proposed research clearly

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stated? In the Background Section and/or the Literature Review, does the PD/PI cite relevant prior work (by self and others) or other information (e.g., pilot data) that helps to establish the scientific significance of the proposed work?

- Does the investigator provide an explanation of how their project will fill a gap in research?
- Is there a strong scientific premise for the project?
- Does the study address an important Veterans' health problem?
- How will the project advance scientific knowledge or clinical practice?
- What effect will these studies have on the concepts, methods, technologies, treatments, services or preventive interventions that drive this field?
- How will the research, if successful, result in newer therapies and therapeutic approaches, or improve the quality of life and functional independence of Veterans? While every reviewer may not be fully familiar with VA programs and policies, all reviewers will assess the cogency of the argument that the proposed research will make a positive difference in the delivery, management or outcomes of VA health services.
- Does the project add to the evidence base of the utility of Psychedelic use in Veterans?
- Does the project address any of the gaps in research identified in the Psychedelic State of the Art (SOTA) meeting?

Innovation:

- Is the project original and innovative?
- Does the project challenge existing paradigms or clinical practice or address an innovative hypothesis or critical barrier to progress in the field?
- Does the project develop or employ novel concepts, approaches or methodologies, tools or technologies for this area?
- How will the research take advantage of unique capabilities of the VHA health system to explore questions that might be difficult to answer in other systems.

Impact:

- Does the proposed research address a problem that is important and would a solution affect healthcare delivery and outcomes in the VA, nationwide and beyond?
- How will the research, if successful, improve the well-being of the whole person, including, quality of life, happiness, sense of purpose, health, social, and functional independence of Veterans? While every reviewer may not be fully familiar with VA programs and policies, all reviewers will assess the cogency of the argument that the proposed research will make a positive difference in the delivery, management or outcomes of VA health services.

Methods:

- Are the strengths and weaknesses of the research design and methods proposed, including whether the conceptual or clinical framework, design, methods and analyses are adequately developed, well-integrated, well-reasoned and appropriate to the aims of the project?
- Does the PD/PI acknowledge potential problem areas and consider alternative approaches?

- Are control groups appropriately constructed/identified.
- What is the accuracy of power calculations, is it based on the prevalence/incidence of the condition in the human population?
- How feasible are the enrollment and sample recruitment timeline?
- Is there sufficient evidence showing that the proposed studies can be successfully completed?
- Are preliminary data based on rigorous scientific study design and the results justify pursuing the proposal?
- If applicable, is there sufficient evidence for successful recruitment and enrollment of human participants or the availability of animal models; and the ability to attain samples and/or data, etc.?
- For primary data, is the proposed data collection instrument(s) or the plan for developing and testing new instruments adequate? Are the data collection procedures feasible and appropriate?
- If secondary data issues will be considered, are the data appropriate, available, accurate and complete for the purposes of the study?
- If proposing the use of existing databases, is there evidence that the PD/PI is familiar with the database and understands the data and its limitations?
- Are quality control procedures adequate, reliable and valid?

Project Organization and Management:

- Is there appropriate distribution of roles and responsibilities across project staff?
- Is there appropriate justification of full-time equivalent (FTE) allocations for each project year?
- Are there plans for coordinating multiple participants, tasks or sites?
- Is the timeline reasonable? Does it show important benchmarks and products and general feasibility of the management plan?

Feasibility:

- Is there sufficient evidence to determine that the proposed studies can be successfully completed?
- If applicable, is there sufficient evidence for successful recruitment and enrollment of subjects?
- Can the required animal models or samples be attained?
- Can the proposed study be completed within the duration of the award?
- Are proposed studies, including animal studies, adequately powered to answer the research questions?
- Are reasonable contingency plans in place?

Investigator Qualifications:

- Does each investigator and major consultant, have the professional credentials, institutional position, role in the project, expertise (especially as reflected in publications) and relevant experience needed for the proposed study?
- Does the combined strength of the team in relation to the objectives of the project bring the necessary, complementary and integrated skills and expertise to the project?
- Is the research team appropriate and does it capitalize on unique expertise or opportunity?
- Does the research team have a track record for success?
- When appropriate, reviewers will be asked to comment on:

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- Implementation expertise of study team
- Qualifications for mixed methods or qualitative analyses

Multiple PI Projects: If applicable:

- Is the rationale for using a multiple PD/PI approach convincing?
- Are the roles for each PD/PI in the project distinct and
- Is the communication plan adequate?
- Is the overall organization and management of the project, the initiation, conduct and completion, feasible?

Facilities and Resources:

- Are the facilities and resources adequate in order to carry out the proposed study?
- Is there evidence of support from the PD/PI's VA facility, support from any additional study site(s) and documentation of any agreements with consultants or commitment of non-VA resources to the study?
- If any non-VA resources are used, are they adequately justified and essential to completing the proposed work?
- Does the scientific environment and its unique features, such as participant populations or collaborative arrangements, contribute to the success of the proposed study?

Additional Review Criteria and Considerations

When determining the scientific merit and impact score, reviewers will consider the following additional items if they are included in an application.

Resubmission Applications: Are responses to comments from the previous SRG review adequate and are improvements in the resubmission application appropriate?

Protection of Human Subjects: Are the inclusion of human participants and the guidelines in place to protect them appropriate? Reviewers will consider the following:

- Risk to participants
- Adequacy of protection against risks
- Potential benefits of the proposed research to the participants and others
- Importance of the knowledge to be gained
- Data and safety monitoring for clinical trials

Reviewers will also assess:

- Plans for recruiting and retaining subjects
- The risk/benefit ratio of the study:
 - Does the study place human participants at risk of physical or psychological harm?
 - Are there adequate provisions to minimize risk, protect participants' privacy, ensure informed

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consent and minimize respondent burden?

Use of non-Veteran subjects is not allowed in these applications.

Inclusion of Women, Minorities and Children:

VA mandates that all research proposals reviewed and funded by ORD include women and minorities in their study populations to the extent possible. See Part II of the VA-ORD SF424.

- Plans to include subjects from both genders and all racial and ethnic groups (and subgroups), as appropriate for the scientific goals of the research.
- The adequacy of representation.
- Whether investigators have made a substantive effort to include women and/or minorities in each research proposal.
- Approval from the VAMC Director if the proposed plans include children.

NOTE: For additional information see [VHA Directive 1200.05 Requirements for the Protection of Human Subjects in Research](#).

Vertebrate Animals: Are the use of vertebrate animals and the guidelines in place to protect them appropriate? Reviewers will consider the following:

- Detailed description of the proposed use of the animals
- Justification for the use of animals and for the appropriateness of the species and numbers proposed
- Adequacy of proposed veterinary care
- Appropriate procedures for limiting pain and distress to that which is unavoidable
- Appropriate methods of euthanasia

For protocols which include canines, felines or non-human primates can it be confirmed that the:

- Scientific objectives directly relate to an illness or injury that is combat-related,
- Scientific value of the work proposed is sufficiently important to justify the use of canines, felines or non-human primates,
- Research cannot be conducted with an alternative model involving less sentient species,
- Computer simulations and in vitro approaches such as tissue culture or organ-on-a chip technology cannot substitute for the proposed animal model,
- Procedures proposed are essential to meet the scientific goals of the project,
- Appropriate statistical analyses to justify numbers of animals, and
- Proposed regulatory pathway for an investigational new product application is comprehensive, logical and indicates where the current proposal fits into the pipeline?

For protocols with non-human primates, can it be confirmed that toxicology studies have been completed on smaller animal models (e.g., rats, mice)?

Biohazards and Radioisotopes: Are materials or procedures proposed potentially hazardous to research personnel and/or the environment and is the proposed protection adequate?

Veteran Engagement Plan – For Human Subjects Research only (Scored HSR&D, Unscored RR&D, CSR&D, BLR&D):

Proposals involving human subjects should include a Veteran Engagement Plan. The appropriate level of engagement will vary with the nature of the project and the target of any interventions included. Researchers could consult with local Veteran Engagement Groups, include Veterans on the study team, use a CONsortia of REsearch (CORE) Veteran Engagement panel, and/or develop a project-specific Veteran Engagement approach. Involvement of Veterans and their caregivers (family and friends) during the study design, development, research, and intervention also allows Veteran end-users the opportunity to provide important insights into what outcomes matter most. This includes Veteran perspectives on the feasibility and acceptance of study designs. In cases where investigators determine that Veteran engagement is not applicable, the PD/PI must provide a clear rationale for that decision.

Reviewers will assess:

- Do the investigators give a convincing rationale for why or why not Veterans are engaged as research partners in this grant? Is the proposal's level of engagement with Veteran stakeholders appropriate for the scope and aims of the project?
- How well does the Veteran Engagement (VE) Plan reflect the needs of the project?
- Is there evidence that Veterans were involved in the design of the research study (early engagement) and that their ideas were appropriately incorporated?
- How appropriate are the proposed VE activities throughout the phases (grant/research/dissemination/implementation) of the project? Is there good alignment?
- Are there appropriate forms of support for proposed VE activities (staff, activities, budget, compensation for Veterans, etc.)?

Budget (Unscored):

- Is the project budget appropriate for the proposed research, sufficiently detailed and well-justified?
- Is the budget well-justified and adequate?
- Is the project timeline reasonable?
- Are costs appropriately allocated to major budget categories and personnel?
- Are projects staffed properly?
- Do any items appear to be outliers? Do the line items change markedly from one year to another, or are there large amounts included for equipment, travel or subcontracts?

NOTE: Prior to any funding decisions, program review staff will review all projects to ensure that VA research funds are not used for any unauthorized purposes.

Sharing Research Data (Unscored): Is the Data Management and Access Plan (DMAP) or the rationale for not sharing data adequate?

Disapproved Applications: An application may be disapproved if the SRG determines that the proposed studies are unethical or are unlikely to yield useful information. Applications that are disapproved are not given a numerical score and may not be resubmitted. Studies disapproved for ethical considerations may not be carried out in VA space or with VA resources, even if the project is funded by another agency.

Appeals: The appeals process is intended to ensure that the scientific review of all proposals is fair and equitable. It is not intended as a means to resolve differences in scientific opinion between the applicant and the reviewers, to adjust funding decisions or to circumvent the peer review process.

The basis for an appeal and the procedure for submitting an appeal are detailed as below, on the respective service website. Please follow the processes for the respective service as outlined below.

BLR&D & CSR&D: [BLRD & CSR&D Site](#)

HSR&D: [HSR&D site](#)

RR&D: [RR&D site](#) and [Merit Review Appeal Process](#)

Section V. Award Administration Information

Award Notices

After the application has been peer reviewed, PD/PIs can access their Summary Statement (summary of discussion and written critiques) via [eRA Commons](#) once this information has been released by review staff.

If the application is under consideration for funding, ORD will issue a Notice of Intent to Award to the PD/PI and their VAMC R&D Office's ACOS and AO. The PD/PI will also receive an email notification from eRA. SPMs will indicate the applicable JIT areas for the application in the eRA JIT module. When JIT is released, the PD/PI and SO will receive an eRA system notification. The PD/PI and their local R&D office are responsible for completing the required JIT documents to bring the study into compliance. For a project to remain under consideration for funding, ORD must receive all JIT items via the VA JIT Document Manager within 180 days of the Notice of Intent to Award.

If an application is not under further consideration for award, the status in eRA Commons will be "NRFC" (Not Recommended for Consideration) and the PD/PI will receive an email notification from eRA.

Administrative and National Policy Requirements

Research Integrity: ORD is committed to the highest standards for the ethical conduct of research. Maintenance of high ethical standards requires that VAMCs and investigators applying for and Psychedelics Parent Merit Review Award, (I01)

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receiving Merit Review Awards have appropriate procedures to preclude the occurrence of unethical research practices.

The PD/PI and others associated with the research must subscribe to accepted standards of rational experimental research design, accurate data recording, unbiased reporting of data, respect for the intellectual property of other investigators, adherence to established ethical codes, legal standards for the protection of Human and Animal Subjects and proper management of research funds.

Deliberate falsification or misrepresentation of research data will result in withdrawal of an application, possible suspension or termination of an award and potentially suspension of a PD/PI's eligibility to submit applications to ORD.

Acknowledging VA Research Support: By accepting a Merit Review Award, PD/PIs agree to properly acknowledge VA affiliation and support in all public reports and presentations (see [VHA Directive 1200.19 Presentation of Research Results](#)). Failure to acknowledge VA affiliation and support may result in termination of the award.

Intellectual Property Rights: By accepting a Merit Review Award, PD/PIs agree to comply with VA policies regarding intellectual property (VA invention documents and certifications), disclosure obligations and Federal Government ownership rights resulting from the proposed work (see [VHA Directive 1200.18 Determination of Rights for Inventions and Discoveries](#)).

Annual and Final Reports: By accepting a Merit Review Award, PD/PIs agree to complete and submit via eRA Commons an annual Federal-wide research performance progress report (RPPR) for the project and a Final RPPR in Closeout Status following the project period end date (PPED). Information and instructions can be found [here](#).

Clinical Trials: Accepted with FOA/RFA.

Integrity of Review: ORD is committed to supporting the highest ethical standards for the review process. This includes maintaining the confidentiality of review, preventing improper influences on reviewers and identifying and managing potential conflicts of interest during the review process.

Applicants who contact reviewers about their proposals or about the review process or otherwise attempt to influence the review process will be subject to sanctioning up to and including permanent loss of eligibility to submit. Reviewers are expected to report to the SPM involved any attempts by applicants to contact them.

Section VI. Agency Contacts

ORD encourages scientific/programmatic inquiries concerning this funding opportunity and welcomes the opportunity to answer any questions.

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Scientific/Research Contacts

Programmatic inquiries related to Merit Review Award submission or review should be made by the PD/PI's ACOS or AO and directed to the Service Program Review staff. Contact the SPMs with questions regarding scientific issues raised in the summary statement or the scientific content of an application to be submitted. Contact information for staff:

Dr. Vetisha L. McClair, Vetisha.McClair@va.gov

For Grants.gov or eRA Commons questions/issues: vhacordera.vhacordera@va.gov.

Financial Management Contacts

BLR&D: Sara Clark, Sara.Clark@va.gov

CSR&D: Lisa Eiben, Lisa.Eiben@va.gov

HSR&D: Diane Murphy, Diane.Murphy3@va.gov

RR&D: Tiffany Asqueri, Tiffany.Asqueri@va.gov